MAHARASHTRA

SHINDE EYES NEW TARGETS

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni



COMMON GROUND Eknath Shinde, Devendra Fadnavis and Amit Shah at Raigad Fort, Apr. 12

ANI

On April 13, the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) got its latest shock when Sanjana Ghadi, who was made the party spokesperson just days before, joined the rival Shiv Sena led by deputy CM Eknath Shinde along with husband and former Mumbai corporator Sanjay Ghadi. But then, this was only the latest in a series of defections that have bedevilled the SS (UBT).

Former MLAs Rajan Salvi, Subhash Bane, Sanjay Kadam, Sujit Minchekar and ex-MLC Dushyant Chaturvedi are some of the big names who have shifted camps. In Mumbai, influential ex-corporators Rajul Patel and Raju Pednekar are also now on Shinde's side, as is Nandakumar Ghodele, the former mayor of Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (Aurangabad). The Shinde Sena now claims the loyalty of over half of the Shiv Sena's 97 corporators in the outgoing Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), whose term ended in 2022. Meanwhile, reports of an 'Operation Tiger' to wean away some of the Shiv Sena UBT's nine Lok Sabha MPs and 20 MLAs are doing the rounds. The presence of certain UBT Sena MPs at events hosted by Shinde's men in New Delhi has added further grist to the rumour mills.

A worried Shiv Sena UBT legislator admitted the party has yet to recover from the November 2024 assembly election defeat. "There is a sense of fatigue among the cadre and the middle rung," he says. "Functionaries and workers with business interests linked to the government have no option but to jump ship." But what is Shinde's gameplan in all this? The defections to Shinde's side come at a time when the deputy CM is increasingly being seen as 'marginalised' in the three-party Mahayuti alliance, a far cry from the time when he called the shots as chief minister (2022-24). Shinde met Union home minister Amit Shah during the latter's visit to Maharashtra on April 13 to reportedly discuss these concerns.

In public, Shinde and other Mahayuti leaders from the BJP and NCP have persistently denied any rift. But some of his recent inductions suggest he is shoring up his options. Shinde took a personal interest in roping in ex-Congress MLA (and former Sainik) Ravindra Dhangekar, who had inflicted a shock defeat on the BJP in the byelections to the saffron stronghold of Kasba Peth in Pune in 2022.

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Taking in former three-term MLA Rajan Salvi will also serve as a check on the rising influence of another Sena leader and industries minister, Uday Samant, and his brother Kiran a.k.a. Bhaiyya, who had defeated Salvi in 2024 from Rajapur in Ratnagiri district. Despite being part of Shinde's party, the Samant brothers are said to be cosying up to the BJP.

Shinde's ground is also shaky as some seven of his MLAs are ex-BJP, including Nilesh Rane, Sanjana Jadhav and Rajendra Gavit. Sources say that with the new recruits, the deputy CM is trying to increase his bargaining power while also showing senior ally BJP that he can't be taken for granted. The Shinde Sena has 57 MLAs and seven MPs but is not critical to the Mahayuti government's stability in Maharashtra. One turning point could be the elections to the local bodies, including the all-important BMC, that should take place later this year. A win in the BMC poll will put an end to any ambiguities about the Shinde Sena within the alliance and also settle once and for all which is the 'real Shiv Sena'. ■